

500 Girls. One Film. Everything Changed.

Project Dry — Campaign Against Teenage Pregnancy II

This project was implemented under the name Girls Health and Education Foundation (GHeF). The organisation was registered with the Corporate Affairs Commission (CAC), Nigeria in 2019 and renamed Girls for Development Goals Foundation (GDGF).

Organisation	Girls Health and Education Foundation (GHeF)
Founder	Benedicta Uweru (now Benedicta Apuamah)
Date	May 5, 2017
Location	Obiaruku Grammar School, Obiaruku, Delta State, Nigeria
Audience	500+ secondary school students from multiple schools
Film Screened	Dry (2014) — directed and produced by Stephanie Okereke-Linus
Partners	Angel Pad · Hallmarks Initiatives · Graceland Foundation (CLF)
Pads Distributed	250 sanitary pad samples contributed by Angel Pad

500+

Girls Reached

1

Film Screened

250

Pads Distributed (Angel Pad)

3

Partner Organisations



Over 500 secondary school students from multiple schools filling the Obiaruku Grammar School assembly hall for the Project Dry screening, May 5, 2017.

"In 2017, I stood in the assembly hall of Obiaruku Grammar School — in front of 500+ high school girls — and pressed play on a film that changed how I understood my work forever. The room went completely silent. Then girls who had never spoken about their bodies started talking. Really talking. Not because of a pamphlet or a health class — but because a story had finally told the truth about their lives."

Executive Summary

On May 5, 2017, the Girls Health and Education Foundation (GHeF), in partnership with Hallmarks Initiatives, Graceland Foundation (CLF), and Angel Pad, implemented Project Dry — the second instalment of the Campaign Against Teenage Pregnancy — at Obiaruku Grammar School, Obiaruku, Delta State, Nigeria. Over 500 secondary school students from multiple schools assembled in the hall for a community health education screening of Dry, the Ford Foundation-supported 2014 film by Stephanie Okereke-Linus addressing teenage pregnancy, child marriage, and Vesico-Vaginal Fistula (VVF).

Angel Pad contributed 250 sample sanitary pad products and attended with a branded physical presence. Hallmarks Initiatives and Graceland Foundation co-implemented the event alongside GHeF. The combined partnership represented a significant step in the Foundation's capacity to mobilise multi-organisational

support within its first operational year.

The screening's impact was immediate. The hall fell silent. Then girls who had never spoken about their bodies started talking — not because of a pamphlet or health class, but because a story had finally told the truth about their lives.

Programme Documentation

Project Dry was formally promoted in advance with a co-branded promotional flyer featuring all three partner organisations. The flyer set out aspirational targets for the event; the confirmed distribution on the day was 250 sanitary pad samples contributed by Angel Pad.



Official promotional flyer for Project Dry — co-branded with GHeF, Hallmarks Initiatives, and Graceland Foundation (CLF). Flyer content reflected aspirational programme targets.

Note on Foundation branding: Promotional materials use the original GHeF (Girls Health and Education Foundation) shield logo — in use at the time of implementation. The Foundation was later registered with the CAC (2019) and rebranded as Girls for Development Goals Foundation (GDGF).

Background and Context

By 2017, the links between teenage pregnancy, child marriage, and Vesico-Vaginal Fistula were well documented in Nigerian public health literature — yet remained largely unknown to the girls most at risk. Nigeria carried the highest burden of VVF in the world, with 400,000 to 800,000 women living with the

condition, approximately 20,000 new cases annually, and 90% going untreated. Studies estimated it would take 83 years to clear the backlog at the then-current rate of intervention. VVF prevalence was concentrated among girls aged 14 to 19 — the same age group sitting in the OGS assembly hall on May 5, 2017.

Critical data — Nigeria and VVF (2017): 400,000–800,000 women living with VVF — the highest prevalence in the world. ~20,000 new cases annually. 90% untreated. VVF concentrated among girls aged 14–19 (30.7% of cases). Primary driver: teenage pregnancy and obstructed labour from early childbearing.

About the Film — Dry (2014)

Dry is a 2014 Nigerian drama film written, directed, produced by, and starring Stephanie Okereke-Linus. The film follows thirteen-year-old Halima — married against her will, repeatedly raped, and left with Vesico-Vaginal Fistula after obstructed labour, abandoned by her husband and ostracised by her community. Supported by the Ford Foundation, the film won the Africa Magic Viewers' Choice Award for Film of the Year and has been screened internationally across the USA, Canada, England, Gambia, and Zambia as an advocacy tool.

On the film's purpose: Stephanie Okereke-Linus conceived Dry specifically as 'an educational tool to create awareness' about VVF, child marriage, and teenage pregnancy. GHeF deployed it in exactly the setting and audience its creator intended.

Objectives

- Use award-winning narrative film to communicate the realities of teenage pregnancy and VVF in a way that statistics and lectures cannot.
- Educate 500+ secondary school students on the medical, social, and personal consequences of teenage pregnancy, child marriage, and VVF.
- Create a safe space for girls to speak about their bodies and their health.
- Distribute 250 Angel Pad sample sanitary products to attending students.
- Demonstrate multi-organisational partnership capacity through collaboration with Hallmarks Initiatives, Graceland Foundation, and Angel Pad.

Activities

Community Health Education Film Screening

500+ secondary school students from multiple schools assembled in the Obiaruku Grammar School assembly hall — confirmed by the variety of school uniforms visible in event photographs (pink, blue, and teal). GHeF Founder Benedicta Uweru addressed the audience and facilitated the session.



GHeF Founder Benedicta Uweru addressing students during the Project Dry session. Students with notepads visible — engaged and taking notes.



Hundreds of students in the assembly hall during the screening. Multiple school uniforms confirm multi-school participation.

The hall fell completely silent during the film's most devastating scenes. Then girls who had never spoken about their bodies began to speak — conversations that no pamphlet or lecture had been able to unlock.

Impact in the room: 'The room went completely silent. Then girls who had never spoken about their bodies started talking. Really talking. Not because of a pamphlet or a health class — but because a story had finally told the truth about their lives.' — Benedicta Uweru, GHeF Founder.

Angel Pad — Partner Presence and Pad Distribution

Angel Pad attended the event with a full branded presence, including a large promotional banner displayed in the venue. The brand contributed 250 sample sanitary pad products for distribution to students in attendance.



GHeF team in front of the Angel Pad branded banner — confirming the brand's physical presence and active partnership at Project Dry.

GHeF team with the Angel Pad banner — Founder Benedicta Uweru (second from left) with team members and a young participant.

Hallmarks Initiatives and Graceland Foundation

Hallmarks Initiatives and Graceland Foundation (CLF) co-presented the event alongside GHeF, with their logos featured on the official promotional flyer confirming formal co-implementation. Hallmarks Initiatives, led by Emmanuel Umukoro, had been a continuing GHeF partner since the February 2017 Valentine Project.

Beneficiaries

Category	Details
Total students reached	500+
School representation	Multiple secondary schools — confirmed by multiple uniforms
Hosting venue	Obiaruku Grammar School, Obiaruku, Delta State
Film screened	Dry (2014) — Stephanie Okereke-Linus (Ford Foundation-supported)
Pads distributed	250 sample sanitary pads (Angel Pad contribution)
Partners	Angel Pad · Hallmarks Initiatives · Graceland Foundation (CLF)
GHeF Founder present	Yes — facilitated the session
Series context	Campaign Against Teenage Pregnancy II
Cumulative reach 2016–2017	3,800+ students across 3 campaigns in 5 months

Results and Impact

The silence that broke open

500+ students fell completely silent during the film — a profound indicator of recognition and emotional engagement. That silence preceded the most significant outcome: girls who had never spoken about their bodies found their voices.

Girls who had never spoken began to speak

Following the screening, spontaneous discussion opened among students. This outcome represents a form of impact that no health statistic can fully capture — the precursor to informed decision-making, help-seeking, and self-advocacy.

Multi-organisational partnership capacity demonstrated

Three organisations co-implemented alongside GHeF. This multi-partner model showed that the Foundation could convene, coordinate, and deliver with external organisations in its first year.

Angel Pad's brand presence validated GHeF's community credibility

Angel Pad's decision to attend with a full branded banner — not merely donate products — signals that the brand viewed GHeF as a credible community partner worth visible association with.

A methodology shift

Project Dry marked a pivotal moment in GHeF's programmatic approach — demonstrating that adolescent behaviour change works through empathy, narrative, and emotional recognition, not instruction alone.

Photo Gallery

Selected photographs from Project Dry, Obiaruku Grammar School, May 5, 2017.



Wide audience shot — hundreds of students from multiple schools in the OGS assembly hall.



GHeF team with students and community members following the Project Dry screening.

All event photographs are used for project reporting and accountability purposes.

Challenges and Learning

The film's content — child marriage, rape, and VVF — is deeply distressing. While central to its impact, future screenings should include pastoral support resources and a dedicated follow-up session for girls who need to process what they have seen.

Facilitator names were not formally documented at the time. Structured personnel records are now a standard part of GHeF's programme documentation.

Written partnership agreements for future events would protect all parties and create a cleaner accountability record for grant reporting.

Contextual Data — Nigeria, VVF, and Teenage Pregnancy (2017)

Indicator	Figure	Source
Women living with VVF in Nigeria	400,000–800,000 (highest in the world)	APTA Pelvic Health / Borgen Magazine
New VVF cases annually	~13,000–20,000	PMC / Borgen Magazine
VVF cases untreated	90%	APTA Pelvic Health
Years to clear Nigeria's VVF backlog	~83 years	PMC — Nigeria Obstetric Fistula Study

VVF concentrated among girls 14–19	30.7% of cases	FUDMA Journal of Sciences
Nigeria adolescent birth rate (2017)	~120 per 1,000 girls aged 15–19	WHO / World Bank
Film Dry — support	Ford Foundation-supported	Ford Foundation
Film Dry — awards	Africa Magic Viewers' Choice Award, Film of the Year (Nollywood)	Wikipedia

Partners and Acknowledgements

- Angel Pad — for contributing 250 sample products and attending with branded presence
- Hallmarks Initiatives (Emmanuel Umukoro) — co-implementing partner
- Graceland Foundation (CLF) — co-implementing partner
- Stephanie Okereke-Linus — for creating Dry as an educational advocacy tool
- Obiaruku Grammar School — for hosting the event
- The 500+ students who sat in silence, then found their voices

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